Leonardo da Vinci and Nikola Tesla.

A man on the inside

It was the infamous Jallianwala Bagh massacre in 1919 that first made Menon appreciate the complexity of his position: he was an ambitious Indian employee of the British government, but was also sympathetic to the idea of a free India. Menon was thus well-positioned to create change from within. He was involved in the drafting of new laws that granted Indians more political representation and power. He also advised at least three British viceroys on the implementation of these laws. Seen as capable and trustworthy, he was handpicked by Vallabhbhai Patel to aid him in the important task of integrating the princely states into India.

WHAT CAME BEFORE THE CONSTITUTION?

Before the Constitution of India was adopted, the Government of India Acts of 1919 and 1935 passed by the British acted as a sort of constitution for British India. These acts set out, among other things, how many Indians could be elected to governing bodies, what their powers would be and which Indians could vote in elections.

The consummate advisor

Menon is mainly remembered today for his work with Patel. But Menon made another lasting contribution during the tumultuous months before 15th August in helping to determine how and to whom power would be transferred when British rule ended. The first proposal made by Lord Mountbatten was that power should be transferred initially to provincial governments, which could then decide whether they wanted to group together, and stay in India or not. In theory, this could have led to the formation of a dozen or more ‘countries’ in the subcontinent. Menon helped formulate the alternative that was finally accepted: the British would hand over power to the governments of two new dominions, India and Pakistan.